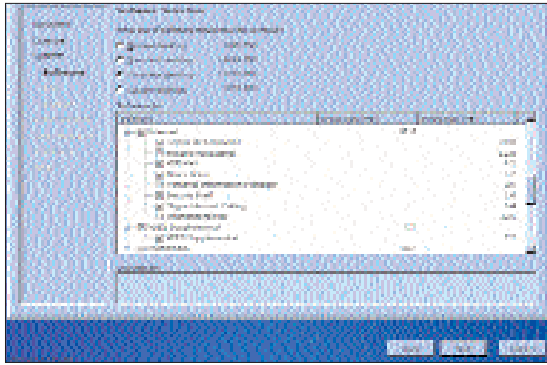




Xandros offers a well polished installation interface. Seen here is the application selection window, a la Win98 style

through the routine of collecting necessary data such as keyboard layout, machine name, and administrator password. On the next screen, it asks you which partitioning method to employ. By default, two options are offered, one to completely take over the hard drive and the second, more advanced one, where you can select the partition to which you want to install the OS.

Once you boot from the Xandros CD, you will be presented with a license agreement—quite unexpected! After accepting the license, the installer moves on to the installation selection, where it offers very familiar looking options—express install and custom install, and a small pane at the bottom offers the explanation for the two options.

This resemblance to the Windows way of installing might put off hardcore Linux gurus, but is a boon for first-timers.

If you select custom install, you can select applications to be loaded by default on the next screen. To make it even easier, there are four preconfigured sets such as minimal, standard, full and custom desktops.

Then you move on to the disk partitioning, where you are offered three options, namely use free space, take over disk and manage disk and partition (advance control).

Partitioning used to be the most critical phase during installation of Linux on a PC, the rudimentary interface wasn't intuitive enough and most first time users wound up with a blank hard drive. Not any more.

The disk partitioning in Xandros is worth mentioning and we think even Microsoft can take a lesson or two from these guys on how to make the UI for parti-

Partitioning used to be the most critical phase during installation of Linux on a PC... and most first time users wound up with a blank hard drive. Not any more

tioning simple and functional. Between the two distro's, we felt Xandros offered a much cleaner and polished interface.

Once the partitioning is done, Xandros offers to set up your network, if any, and you can specify your IP address, gateway, and other details, followed by the computer name and administrator password. Following this, you can add a user if you please—we suggest you do so, as using the system with root privileges is never advisable for a newbie.

Once all the required information is acquired, an installation summary page shows up in both OSes. Before proceeding to the installation, Linspire confirms twice, and then starts off with the installation procedure, whereas Xandros starts off immediately. Both OSes took almost 30 minutes to complete the installation procedure.

During the installation of files, splash screens convey the features built into Linspire to make it a simpler Linux. Though these things are not of great value, it definitely gives a new user a hint of what he can expect of this new OS.

Rember, Xandros offers better control over the installation procedure since it allows you to choose applications that you want to install. Linspire, on the other hand, takes control away from users and by default, configures the machine to a predefined state.

Though this could be good for new users, as they do not have to bother about the applications being loaded, advanced users should at least have the option of choosing what to install.

Overall, we think Xandros sets the standard for other Linux distros to follow when it comes to making a Linux installation a sweat-less affair.



Xandros File manager, gives easy access to your drives, network, shares etc in a simple and elegant manner

Post Installation

Once both the operating systems are installed, a splash screen (with rather big typography) tells you to remove the CD-ROM and press [Enter] to restart the machine.

After a reboot, Linspire presents you with the administrator login, entering the password takes you to the next screen—a License agreement. Then the system does the routine task of setting region, time, date and finally moves on the advanced setting tab, where you can create new users and change network settings.

Xandros, on the other hand, starts up with a first run wizard and takes you through setting up and customising of your system.

In Linspire, the first time you log into your system, an audio tutorial makes sure you get a good hold on the various aspects of the new OS. The audio tutorial is comprehensive, with features to forward, rewind or skip through chapters.

Both OSes were able to detect most of our hardware straight out of the box. We did come across some small issues, but they were solved immediately.

Xandros had set the TFT settings to 1024 x 768, but we were able to change it to 1280 x 1024 without any hiccups.

Linspire, for some reason, wasn't able to boot on the 875 machine, but ran smoothly on the AMD machine. Apart from these issues, we didn't face any problems as far as hardware detection was concerned.

Usability

Moving on to the desktop screen, it is hard to believe you are using a Linux distro. The desktop resembles Windows, and you are greeted by familiar icons up front. Purely on visual appeal, we think Linspire beats the pants off all other distros, including Xandros.

Though both of them use the KDE environment, Linspire has done a commendable amount of work to add eye-candy. Both desktops are well organised and uncluttered, and you have all the necessary icons up front.

A Windows user is so accustomed to the 'Start' button, so to make that relation there's the 'Launch' buttons on both OSes. Click on them and you have the application menu, control centre, recently used applications, and the usual features. While there